

On Immortality

Concluding Unscientific Postscript, pp. 153–158

Søren Kierkegaard

Translated by David F. Swenson and Walter Lowrie

When death thus becomes something to be related to the entire life of the subject, I must confess I am very far indeed from having understood it, even if it were to cost me my life to make this confession. Still less have I realized the task existentially. And yet I have thought about this subject again and again; I have sought for guidance in books—and I have found none.¹

For example, what does it mean to be immortal? In this respect, I know what people generally know. I know that some hold a belief in immortality, that others say they do not hold it; whether they actually do not hold it I know not; it does not occur to me therefore to want to combat them, for such an undertaking is so dialectically difficult that I should need a year and a day before it could become dialectically clear to me whether there is any reality in such a contest; whether the dialectic of communication, when it is properly understood, would approve of such a proceeding or transform it into a mere beating of the air; whether the consciousness of immortality is a doctrinal topic

¹Although I have said this often, I wish here again to repeat it: what is developed in these pages does not concern the simple-minded, who bear feelingly the burdens of life, and whom God wishes to preserve in their lovable simplicity, which feels no great need of any other sort of understanding. Or in so far as such need is felt, it tends to reduce itself to a sigh over the ills of life, the sigh humbly finding solace in the thought that the real happiness of life does not consist in having knowledge. On the other hand it does concern those who deem themselves possessed of leisure and talent for a deeper inquiry. And it concerns such an one in the following manner: it seeks to estop him from thoughtlessly taking on universal rotatory motion, without first considering in self-reflection that being an existing human individual is so strenuous and yet so natural a task for everyone, that one tends first as a matter of courage to apply himself to this task, and reasonably finds in the exertion thereto requisite, a sufficiency for his entire life.

which is appropriate as a subject for instruction, and how the dialectic of instruction must be determined with relation to the learner's presuppositions; whether these presuppositions are not so essential that the instruction becomes a deception in case one is not at once aware of them, and in that event the instruction is transformed into non-instruction. Moreover, I know that some have found immortality in Hegel, others have not; I know that I have not found it in the System, where indeed it is also unreasonable to seek it; for, in a fantastic sense, all systematic thinking is *sub specie aeterni*, and to that extent immortality is there in the sense of eternity, but this immortality is not at all the one about which the question is asked, since the question is about the immortality of a mortal, which is not answered by showing that the eternal is immortal, and the immortality of the eternal is a tautology and a misuse of words. I have read Professor Heiberg's *Soul after Death*, indeed I have read it with the commentary of Dean Tryde. Would I had not done so; for one rejoices aesthetically in a poetic word and does not require the utmost dialectical precision which is appropriate in the case of a learner who would direct his life in accordance with such guidance. If a commentator compels me to seek for something of that sort in the poem, he has done no service to the poem. From the commentator I could perhaps hope to learn what I have not learnt from the commentary, if Dean Tryde with catechetical instruction were to take pity on me and show how one constructs a life-view upon the profundities he has propounded by paraphrasing the poem. For honor be to Dean Tryde—merely from that little article it would surely be possible to construct several different life-views—but I cannot make one out of it, and that, alas, is precisely the misfortune, for it is one I need, no more, since I am not a learned man. I know, moreover, that the late Professor Poul Møller, who was well acquainted after all with the newest philosophy, became aware only in his latest period of the infinite difficulty of the question of immortality, when the question is simply put, when one does not ask about a new proof and about the opinions of Tom, Dick and Harry strung upon a thread. I know also that in a treatise he sought to explain himself, and that this treatise clearly bears the mark of his aversion to speculation. The difficulty of the question arises precisely when it is simply put, not as the well-trained *Privatdocent* enquires about the immortality of man, the abstractly understood man in general, man

being understood fantastically as the race, and so about the immortality of the human race. Such a well-trained *Privatdocent* raises and answers the question in such a way as the well-trained reader conceives that it ought to be done. A poor untrained reader is only made a fool of by such reflections, like one who overhears an examination in which the questions and answers have been agreed upon beforehand, or like one who enters a family circle which has its own language, using words of the mother tongue, but understanding something different by them. A book raises the question of the immortality of the soul. The contents of the book constitute the answer. But the contents of the book, as the reader can convince himself by reading it through, are the opinions of the wisest and best men about immortality, all neatly strung on a thread. Oh! thou great Chinese god! Is this immortality? So then the question about immortality is a learned question. All honor to learning! All honor to him who can handle learnedly the learned question of immortality! But the question of immortality is essentially not a learned question, rather it is a question of inwardness, which the subject by becoming subjective must put to himself. Objectively the question cannot be answered, because objectively it cannot be put, since immortality precisely is the potentiation and highest development of the developed subjectivity. Only by really willing to become subjective can the question properly emerge, therefore how could it be answered objectively? The question cannot be answered in social terms, for in social terms it cannot be expressed, inasmuch as only the subject who wills to become subjective can conceive the question and ask rightly, "Do I become immortal, or am I immortal?" Of course, people can combine for many things; thus several families can combine for a box at the theater, and three single gentlemen can combine for a riding horse, so that each of them rides every third day. But it is not so with immortality; the consciousness of my immortality belongs to me alone, precisely at the moment when I am conscious of my immortality I am absolutely subjective, and I cannot become immortal in partnership with three single gentlemen in turn. People who go about with a paper soliciting the endorsement of numerous men and women, who feel a need in general to become immortal, get no reward for their pains, for immortality is not a possession which can be extorted by a list of endorsements. Systematically, immortality cannot be proved at all. The fault does not lie in the proofs, but in the

fact that people will not understand that viewed systematically the whole question is nonsense, so that instead of seeking outward proofs, one had better seek to become a little subjective. Immortality is the most passionate interest of subjectivity; precisely in the interest lies the proof. When for the sake of objectivity (quite consistently from the systematic point of view), one systematically ignores the interest, God only knows in this case what immortality is, or even what is the sense of wishing to prove it, or how one could get into one's head the fixed idea of bothering about it. If one were systematically to hang up immortality on the wall, like Gessler's hat, before which we take off our hats as we pass by, that would not be equivalent to being immortal or to being conscious of one's immortality. The incredible pains the System takes to prove immortality is labor lost and a ludicrous contradiction—to want to answer systematically a question which possesses the remarkable trait that systematically it cannot be put. This is like wanting to paint Mars in the armor which rendered him invisible. The very point lies in the invisibility; and in the case of immortality, the point lies in the subjectivity and in the subjective development of the subjectivity.

Quite simply therefore the existing subject asks, not about immortality in general, for such a phantom has no existence, but about his immortality, about what it means to become immortal, whether he is able to contribute anything to the accomplishment of this end, or whether he becomes immortal as a matter of course, or whether he is that and can become it. In the first case, he asks what significance it may have, if any, that he has let time pass unutilized, whether there is perhaps a greater and a lesser immortality. In the second case, he asks what significance it may have for the whole of his human existence that the highest thing in life becomes something like a prank, so that the passion of freedom within him is relegated to lower tasks but has nothing to do with the highest, not even negatively, for a negative employment with relation to the highest thing would in a way be the most extenuating—when one wanted to do everything enthusiastically with all one's might, and then to ascertain that the utmost one can do is to maintain a receptive attitude towards that thing which one would more than gladly do everything to earn. The question is raised, how he is to comport himself in talking about his immortality, how he can at one and the same time talk from the standpoint of infinity and of finiteness and think these two

together in one single instant, so that he does not say now the one and now the other; how language and all modes of communication are related thereto, when all depends upon being consistent in every word, lest the little heedless supplementary word, the chatty subordinate phrase, might intervene and mock the whole thing; where may be the place, so to speak, for talking about immortality, where such a place exists, since he well knows how many pulpits there are in Copenhagen, and that there are two chairs of philosophy, but where the place is which is the unity of infinitude and finiteness, where he, who is at one and the same time infinite and finite, can talk in one breath of his infinitude and his finiteness, whether it is possible to find a place so dialectically difficult, which nevertheless is so necessary to find. The question is raised, how he, while he exists, can hold fast his consciousness of immortality, lest the metaphysical conception of immortality proceed to confuse the ethical and reduce it to an illusion; for ethically, everything culminates in immortality, without which the ethical is merely use and wont, and metaphysically, immortality swallows up existence, yea, the seventy years of existence, as a thing of naught, and yet ethically this naught must be of infinite importance. The question is raised, how immortality practically transforms his life; in what sense he must have the consciousness of it always present to him, or whether perhaps it is enough to think this thought once for all, whether it is not true that, if the answer is to this effect, the answer shows that the problem has not been stated, inasmuch as to such a consciousness of immortality once for all there would correspond the notion of being a subject as it were in general, whereby the question about immortality is made fantastically ludicrous, just as the converse is ludicrous, when people who have fantastically made a mess of everything and have been every possible sort of thing, one day ask the clergyman with deep concern whether in the beyond they will then really be the same—after never having been able in their lifetime to be the same for a fortnight, and hence have undergone all sorts of transformations. Thus immortality would be indeed an extraordinary metamorphosis if it could transform such an inhuman centipede into an eternal identity with itself, which this “being the same” amounts to. He asks about whether it is now definitely determined that he is immortal, about what this determinateness of immortality is; whether this determinateness, when he lets it pass for something once

for all determined (employing his life to attend to his fields, to take to himself a wife, to arrange world-history) is not precisely indeterminateness, so that in spite of all determinateness he has not got any further, because the problem is not even conceived, but since he has not employed his life to become subjective, his subjectivity has become some sort of an indeterminate something in general, and that abstract determinateness has become therefore precisely indeterminateness; whether this determinateness (if he employs his life to become subjective) is not rendered so dialectically difficult, by the constant effort to adapt himself to the alternation which is characteristic of existence, that it becomes indeterminateness; whether, if this is the highest he attains to (namely, that the determinateness becomes indeterminateness), it were not better to give the whole thing up; or whether he is to fix his whole passion upon the indeterminateness, and with infinite passionateness embrace the indeterminateness of the determinate; and whether this might be the only way by which he can attain knowledge of his immortality so long as he is existing, because as exister he is marvelously compounded, so that the determinateness of immortality can only be possessed determinately by the Eternal, but by an exister can be possessed only in indeterminateness.

And the fact of asking about his immortality is at the same time for the existing subject who raises the question a deed—as it is not, to be sure, for absent-minded people who once in a while ask about the matter of being immortal quite in general, as if immortality were something one has once in a while, and the question were some sort of thing in general. So he asks how he is to behave in order to express in existence his immortality, whether he is really expressing it; and for the time being, he is satisfied with this task, which surely must be enough to last a man a lifetime since it is to last for an eternity. And then? Well, then, when he has completed this task, then comes the turn for world-history. In these days, to be sure, it is just the other way round: now people apply themselves first to world-history, and therefore there comes out of this the ludicrous result (as another author has remarked) that while people are proving and proving immortality quite in general, faith in immortality is more and more diminishing.